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3 A carrier fitted to a faceplate was mounted on the lathe, ready for the top to be held in place

4 The tailstock was brought into position with the live centre fitting into the middle of the plug. Pressure from the tailstock was sufficient to hold the top securely centred in preparation for turning. Now for the first stage of turning

5 The underneath and profile were reshaped and sanded smooth, replicating profiles of the existing design. This was simply a case of 'cleaning up' what was already there and refining details – getting rid of tear-out, etc.

6 Ready for the top to be reversed, a screw was driven into the plug so it could be removed with the aid of pliers. The force of the tailstock had actually driven the plug into a much tighter fit than I'd originally expected... another example of drawing on one's repertoire of problem-solving skills needed in situations such as this

7 To remount the top so the upper surface could be cleaned up, I fitted a scrap piece of wood into a chuck and turned a 25mm spigot, in essence making another carrier to replace the tenon at the top of the table's pedestal. This is the key skill needed in this type of situation – figuring out how to remount almost completed components so they can be finished off

8 With a support block held in place with the tailstock, the table top was secured so its upper surface could be flattened...

9 ...and sanded smooth. Checked with a steel rule for flatness, the final surface would be hand sanded with a sanding block once removed from the lathe

10 Remounting the pedestal was easy at one end, but at the other I needed to establish the centre of a round stub, ready to be held in place at the tailstock end of my lathe, so I used my finger gauge – two fingers and a thumb gripping a pen, sliding fingers along the perimeter of the stub several times until marked lines gave me an indication of where I could estimate the centre of marks and hence the centre of the pedestal

HANDY HINTS

1. Although this table is only 400mm high you could easily enlarge it to suit your needs. I feel the proportions are quite pleasing aesthetically
2. When chopping mortises, use a broad chisel to pare the sides. I used a 25mm chisel. A proper mortising chisel is needed to clear the base of the joint

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